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Students' Experiences of Bullying in High School and Their Adjustment and Motivation During the First Semester of College

Thesis Statement

This study argues that experiences of being bullied in high school have long-term effects that influence students' motivation and their academic, social, and emotional adjustment during the first semester of college.

Main Ideas

The article explains that bullying is a destructive experience that affects students both psychologically and academically. It emphasizes that high school bullying experiences are associated with decreased motivation to attend college, particularly through increased amotivation and reduced extrinsic motivation. In addition, the study shows that bullying experiences are related to difficulties in first-semester college adjustment, including academic adjustment, social adjustment, personal-emotional adjustment, and institutional attachment. Overall, the effects of bullying do not automatically disappear when students enter a new educational environment, such as college.

Supporting Details

The study examines four types of bullying: relational-verbal bullying, cyberbullying, physical bullying, and culture-based bullying. Motivation is analyzed using Self-Determination Theory, which includes amotivation, extrinsic motivation, and intrinsic motivation. Adjustment is measured through academic adjustment, social adjustment, personal-emotional adjustment, and institutional attachment. The findings indicate that higher levels of bullying in high school are associated with higher levels of amotivation, lower levels of extrinsic motivation, and lower levels of academic, social, and emotional adjustment during the first semester of college.

Key Point by Section

- **Introduction**

The introduction explains that the transition from high school to college is an important yet challenging period for many students. While college can offer new opportunities for growth, some students struggle with adjustment during their first semester. The authors highlight that students who experienced bullying in high school may face additional social and emotional difficulties. The main purpose of the study is to determine whether high school bullying experiences influence students' motivation and adjustment during their first semester in college.

- **Literature Review**

The literature review defines bullying as repeated aggressive behavior involving a power imbalance and discusses its long-term psychological and academic consequences. The authors explain Self-Determination Theory, which states that students' motivation depends on the fulfillment of three basic psychological needs: autonomy, competence, and relatedness. Bullying may prevent students from fulfilling these needs, which can lead to lower motivation and adjustment problems. Based on this theoretical framework, the researchers propose hypotheses linking bullying experiences to amotivation, reduced motivation, and poor adjustment in college.

- **Method**

The study involved 149 first-year college students who completed questionnaires during the first month of their first semester. Participants reported their high school bullying experiences retrospectively and described their current motivation and adjustment to college. The researchers used validated instruments to measure bullying, motivation, and adjustment, and analyzed the data using canonical correlation analysis.

- **Results**

The results show that high school bullying is positively related to amotivation and negatively related to certain types of extrinsic motivation. Furthermore, higher levels of bullying are associated with lower academic adjustment, social adjustment, personal-emotional adjustment, and institutional attachment. Relational-verbal bullying appears to have a particularly strong impact on academic and emotional adjustment during the first semester.

- **Discussion**

The discussion concludes that the effects of high school bullying continue into college. Students who were victimized tend to enter college with lower motivation and greater adjustment difficulties. The authors suggest that these effects may result from lingering negative perceptions of education or from continued victimization in college. They recommend that universities provide support programs that address students' psychological needs in order to improve motivation, adjustment, and overall well-being.